Outfit & Bag Checklist

Decisions the night before are free; decisions at 8:42 a.m. cost something. Check it once, then go to sleep.

Dress one notch above the job's normal day. Comfortable beats impressive — you need your full attention for words, not for shoes.

OUTFIT

- [ ] Set out the whole outfit — including the belt, socks, and the layer.
- [ ] Ironed or steamed (or hanging in the bathroom while you shower — that works).
- [ ] Shoes: closed, quiet, already broken in. New shoes sneak blisters.
- [ ] Nothing that jingles, squeaks, or needs fixing mid-meeting.
- [ ] A layer for aggressive air conditioning.
- [ ] Backup option ready, in case the first one betrays you at the last minute (button, stain, cat hair).
- [ ] Weather plan: umbrella, coat, or sunglasses as the day demands.
- [ ] My extras: _____

> Nobody at an interview has ever hired (or not hired) someone over a shirt. "Clean, fits, comfortable" clears the bar. You're allowed to spend tomorrow's worry on your answers instead.

THE BAG

- [ ] Extra copies of your résumé — one person can unplanned-join any meeting.
- [ ] Notepad and two pens (pens keep alliances with other pens).
- [ ] Your printed sheets: questions to ask, and the story titles from the STAR worksheet.
- [ ] Phone: silenced AND pocketed before you walk in. Not the table.
- [ ] Water and a quiet snack for before or after.
- [ ] ID, keys, directions or the transit plan, parking pass if there is one.
- [ ] Tissues, and something for the trip home you'll want: gum, a charger, etc.
- [ ] One thing that makes you feel like you: a lucky pen counts.

Tune-up, ten minutes

- [ ] Read your three STAR story titles out loud once.
- [ ] Pick your top two questions to ask.
- [ ] Anything left, it can stay left. You've got plenty.

Walking in knowing the bag is handled is not a small thing. It's the reason your hands are free to shake one — warm, and only a little.